

Witness Statement Raymond Okafor

CLAIMANT · WITNESS

- 1 I am Raymond Okafor, Head of Retail Operations at Meridian Retail Group plc. I make this statement from my own knowledge save where otherwise indicated. I am responsible for the running of our store estate.
- 2 The new platform went live on 18 November 2024, immediately before our peak trading period. The first few weeks were very difficult for store teams, particularly because of stock figures being wrong at the tills on the new system.
- 3 That said, I should be straight about the wider picture. A number of the till outages in stores turned out to be caused by the broadband connections in the stores dropping out, rather than the platform itself. There was also a complete outage on 25 November that I am told was a network failure at our data centre provider, not the platform.
- 4 Our trading in December 2024 was poor, but the platform was not the only reason. Our distribution centre at Lutterworth flooded on 3 December 2024 and was effectively out of action for about ten days, which left around 40 stores short of stock on key lines in the first half of December. The market was also weak that quarter, with footfall down across the sector and heavy discounting by competitors.
- 5 I raised these points internally at the time, including in an email to Helena Vance on 8 December 2024, because I was concerned we should not put the whole of a bad December down to the platform when there were other significant factors.
- 6 None of this is to say the platform problems did not hurt us - they did, especially the stock-sync issues - but they were one factor among several.